

LEFT'S NEW HOPE
CPI(M) West Bengal state secretary, Mohammed Salim

VIKRAM SHARMA

WEST BENGAL

Can Salim Save What's Left?

By Romita Datta

It has been a decade of eclipse for the party that has coincided with a serious deficit in leadership. Ever since Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee went into political obscurity, the Bengal unit of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) has pined for a face with a natural acceptance among people—even if sans the iconic stature of a Jyoti Basu or a Buddhadeb. In electing the affable 64-year-old Mohammed Salim, politburo member and former MP, as the state secretary, it may have moved towards a creative solution.

Known for his wit in Parliament and a light demeanour that occasionally breaks into measured invective towards political opponents, Salim is a chip of the old block. The tenure of outgoing secretary Surjya Kanta Mishra was seen as somewhat insipid—nowhere near old Basu-era commissars like Anil Biswas and Subhas Chakraborty in the capacity for iron-fisted area domination. Can a relative purist steeped in Left values create a turnaround there—dreaming not only of survival but of resurrection?

Some party colleagues see a chance. Says CPI(M) leader Tanmay Bhattacharya, "He is ready to take risks, has fantastic presence of mind and an ability to respond to any crisis. With him, the days of defeatist attitudes and losing trends will be over." Soon after being appointed secretary in the state committee conference that ended on March 17, Salim swung into action. After the Bagtui massacre on March 21, he was the first opposition leader to reach the spot, riding pillion on a motorcycle through narrow lanes to avoid a police cordon. Soon, he was holding forth on an alleged criminal-police nexus and talking of Trinamool Congress politicians amassing "disproportionate assets".

THE NEW CPI(M) WEST BENGAL STATE SECRETARY PLANS TO REVIVE THE LEFT'S SOCIAL ACTIVISM

The surcharged political air offers him a fertile field. The party is moving big into digital means of intervention: an app called 'Paharaye Public' (public as watchmen) has been developed for people to report corruption and criminal activity. The plan is to force lawmakers, police and administration to take action. "Since public servants are failing in their jobs, it's time for people to do it themselves. The self-declared 'paharadar' (watchman—a hint at Mamata, who termed herself thus in 2019) and 'chowkidar' have not done their jobs. So people must be their own watchdogs," Salim tells INDIA TODAY. "We will not let the ruling party and government cover up."

A revival of old-world social activism is also on the agenda. The young Red Volunteers who went to work during the Covid-19 pandemic—helping people, arranging for hospital beds, oxygen cylinders, medicines, food, even funerals—came out of an idea from Salim. The initiative was hugely appreciated, and its impact could be felt in the Kolkata Municipal Corporation results in December 2021, with the CPI(M)'s vote share increasing by seven percentage points over the assembly results.

The trend continued in elections to 107 other municipalities—the CPI(M) garnered two percentage points more than the BJP. Over the years, the party has also suffered a loss of 50,000 members, and over 60 per cent of its members are inactive. This is the area of darkness into which Salim has been parachuted, against reservations from some mid-level leaders but buoyed by a positive feedback from youth and district committee leaders. Elsewhere, the Left is innovating in unusual ways—in Tamil Nadu, for instance, the CPI(M) has plunged into temple politics. Bengal will need a strategic rethink too: for the challenge before Salim, to use a phrase of old Left stalwarts, presents itself in the form of a stark "concrete reality". ■